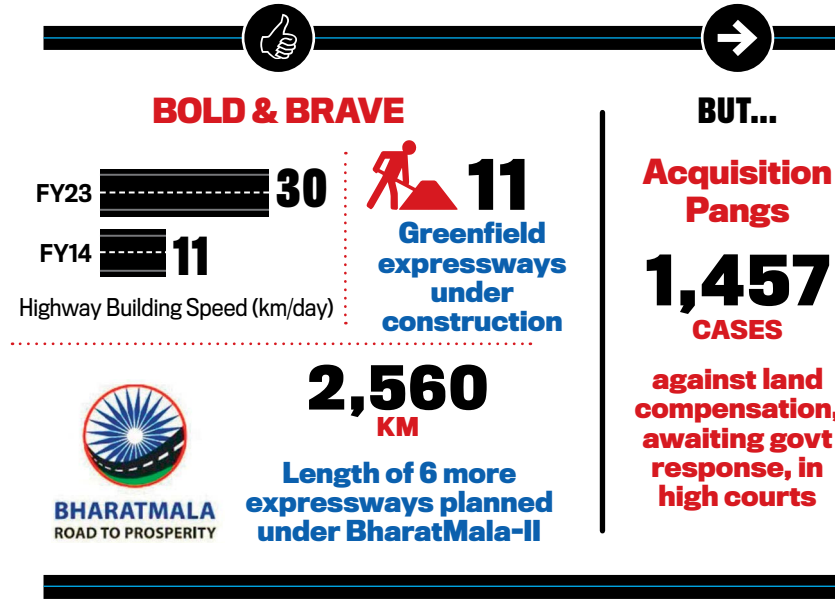
IN A RECENT INTERNAL COMMUNICATION TO HIS OFFICIALS, Nitin Gadkari, the Union minister of road transport and highways, set an ambitious target for them: to construct 60 kilometres of highways every day. It's an uphill task, considering that in FY23, just over 30 km of highways were built on an average daily. The total length of highways thus laid stood at 10,993 km, falling short by 13.7 per cent of the fiscal's target to add 12,500 km.

But Gadkari, who has been at the helm of the ministry since the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) came to power at the Centre in May 2014, is known as a tough taskmaster—setting onerous targets and pushing his officials hard to achieve them. And it is this very trait that has helped him speed up the construction of highways, the lifelines of India's economy.

In fact, Gadkari is perhaps the only minister in Modi Government 2.0 who continues to lead his ministry with the same zeal and consistency he displayed in the first term in the job. When he assumed office, the rot of corporate scams, 'overstretched' balance sheets and a mounting pile of breached contracts had not only slowed down the construction of highways, but also put the country's financial institutions at risk. The then chief economic advisor, Arvind Subramanian, described the situation as a twin balance sheet problem—wherein companies were overleveraged and banks saddled with bad loans. To put things into perspective, we just need to look at the pace of highway construction in 2013-14—just 11 km daily. By the time the parliamentary elections were held in 2019, the speed had accelerated to 20 km per day, and touched 37 km a day in FY21 amid the Covid-induced lockdowns.

Along with expanding the existing highway network, the ministry is also pushing the construction of greenfield expressways—six to 12-lane controlled-access highways for high-speed travel. At present, work is underway on 11 expressways, including the 1,350-km Delhi-Mumbai, 701-km Mumbai-Nagpur, 650-km Delhi-Amritsar-Katra, 465-km Raipur-Visakhapatnam and 594-km Ganga expressway, the last of which will connect Meerut and Prayagraj in Uttar Pradesh. These are in addition to six key expressways—totalling 2,560 km road length—to come up under the second phase of BharatMala projects. Count among them the 745-km Pune-Bengaluru expressway, which will provide the longest expressway link via the Delhi-Mumbai corridor, and the 515-km Indore-Mumbai expressway that too will connect to the upcoming Delhi-Mumbai expressway.



KNOWN FOR HIS PLAIN TALK, GADKARI SUCCEEDS IN GETTING THE WORK DONE EVEN IN STATES RULED BY OPPOSITION PARTIES

Amid these ambitious plans and targets, hurdles in land acquisition remain a major headache for the ministry. As Gadkari told Parliament in February this year, 1,457 cases pertaining to objections to the government-announced compensation for land acquisition were pending in various high courts, wherein the Centre or the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) were yet to file a response.

But Gadkari, known for his plain talk and no-nonsense approach, does succeed in getting the work done, even in states ruled by opposition parties. His influence may have waned within the BJP after he was removed from the party's central election committee and parliamentary board—its top decision-making bodies—but Gadkari's performance as the road transport and highways minister sets him apart from his cabinet colleagues. Now, as India readies to make a transition to cleaner fuel technologies for transport, including vehicles running on hybrid fuel and ultimately electric mobility, Gadkari's experience and business-oriented approach will definitely come in handy. ■